# GLOBAL WASTE TRADE: INFORMAL ECONOMIC PRACTICES OF SOUTHEAST ASIA


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## RESEARCH QUESTION

How is the trade in waste products spatially organized by commodity, what is the social and economic architecture of these circuits of trade, and what forms of employment do they generate?

## CONTEXT

After it is disposed, various forms of waste (whether household garbage, industrial waste, or e-waste) are typically thought not to be of much value. In fact, a dizzying array of waste products are recycled and salvaged for value through formal and informal enterprise. But, academia has been surprisingly inattentive to these forms of enterprise and their geographic make-up. This has left a gap within an extremely important area of research, because the afterlives of waste, in many parts of the global south, provide livelihoods to large segments of the urban poor.

Our study explores urban informal economies in Asia that are involved in the salvage and recycling of various forms of waste. Concurrently, it probes how policies of infrastructure privatization, including waste management, in urban areas of India are continuously marginalizing the urban poor who depend of waste scavenging as a livlihood. Meanwhile, the globalization of trade in waste products, while creating new spaces of employment, is deeply hazardous and raises serious dilemmas about the rights of the poor going forward.

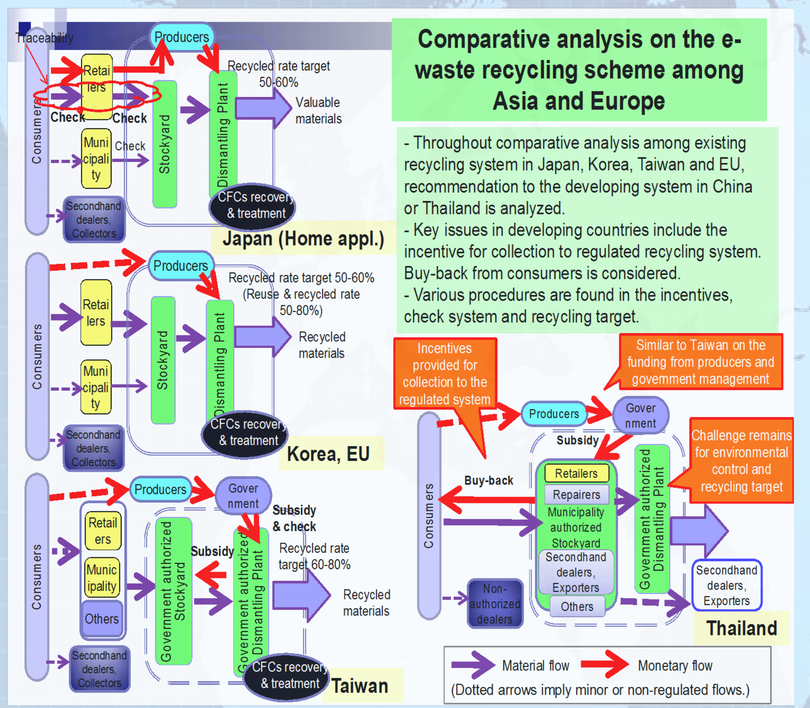


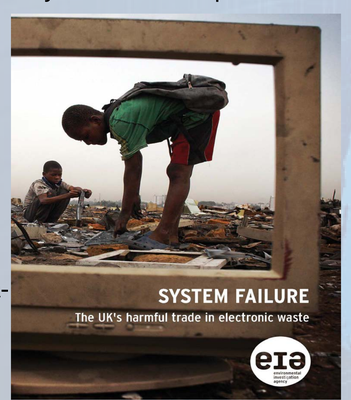

Diagram retrieved from presentation on *Material Flow Analysis on International Recycling* (8 Oct 2010) by Dr. A. Terazono of the National Institute for Environmental Studies, Japan.

## PRELIMINARY FINDINGS

- **Trade flows from North to South**:
  U.S., Japan & EU to China, India & Nigeria.
- **International Trade Flow**:
  China's increasing role in raw imports and dependency relationship with the United States.
- **Regional Trade Flow**:
  1) Strong relationship between NAFTA participants and 2) Relationship between regional Southeast Asian countries due to convenience.
- **Socially Regulated Trade:**
  Community mechanisms serve as a substitute for contract enforcement.
- **Importance of Intermediaries:**
  "Intermediaries" have the greatest purchasing power in low-level trade hierarchy, where waste pickers remained at the bottom of the urban informal sector.
- **Impact of Globalization on geography**:
  1) City restructuring, 2) hazardous conditions of work and living and 3) environmental damage of industrialization (manufacturing industries).

## SIGNIFICANCE OF STUDY

The significance of this study lies in its potential to illuminate an understudied but vitally important aspect of contemporary globalization. This contributes to the currently thin empirical literature on global waste trade, in order to analyze other facets of globalization. By studying waste, we may arrive at a different understanding of the socioeconomic nd ecological impacts of contemporary globalization.




Picture Retrieved from the United nations Environment Programme website: article on *The UK's harmful trade on electronic waste.*

## DATA CONSTRAINTS

- The basis of this research is secondary data; as such we are restricted to compiling and analyzing primary data and verifying our hypothesis.
- Our area of research is also understudied there is relatively little academic literature containing detailed, reliable empirical results.
- Because of the magnitude of each component of this research as well as constraints of time, there were important and pertinent segments of this topic that were left out in order to be more thorough in other areas.
- Finally, it should be reiterated that since this study foregrounds aspects of an informal, and quite often, illegal economy, there is an added layer of complexity and data constraints.

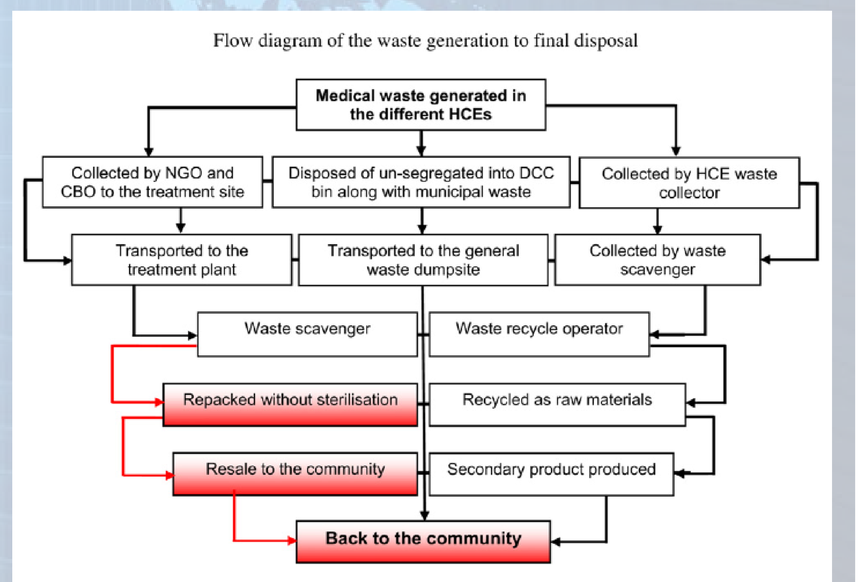



Diagram shows routes of distribution of medical waste from generation to nominal final disposal point. The red color shows most significant route of risk related to medical waste. Retrieved from Journal of Environmental Management (Patwary, 2009).

Background picture retrieved from: http://www.bombasazcue.co.uk/world-map-background.jpg